For as Long as Life Lets Us

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For as Long as Life Lets Us

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Summary

The Acting Grand Master of Mondstad has planned a full dinner for her and her *secret* partner, Lisa Minci. However, the librarian may have a few things to say about it, which Jean couldn't have foreseen. Sometimes, couples need these difficult conversations to test their love; if the feelings are genuine, what could they have to fear?

"My Love, would you… accept being my partner for as long as life lets us?"

Notes

See the end of the work for notes

Jean arrived home carrying several bags of groceries. That afternoon she had made sure Kaeya could take over for the rest of the day and left early to procure all necessary ingredients to prepare a hearty dinner. She'd make it worth the struggle: Her special pizza as the main dish, some cheese cubes to eat before the proper meal, the best wine she could get for them to open that night, and a dessert she hoped Lisa would like. Having calculated the time she would need to get everything ready, she began preparing the pizza dough and, while leaving it to rest, she cooked the dessert. By the time Lisa arrived, the tasty aroma of the pizza was already in the air, and, luckily for her, the table was set already, meaning she could immediately unwind as she had been looking forward to all day.

—Something smells delicious— she commented, taking a seat. The cheese cubes instantly got her attention and the witch suddenly realized how hungry she was. —I wonder what's the occasion— she added, before eating some of the cheese.

—Oh, welcome home, Lisa— Jean greeted her, leaving the kitchen. As soon as she heard her voice, she rushed to get the wine and opened it to serve them both a cup. —No special occasions, Love; or rather, special solely because I decided to cook dinner tonight— she replied, a bit awkwardly, and offered her the cup.

The witch accepted it and made a show of appreciating the wine so she could consider what to answer. This had to be yet another one of Jean's less-than-subtle attentions for her, and now she *had* to turn it down somehow. But how could she possibly be so rude? With all the work Jean had put into preparing the dinner: she could smell her special pizza, which probably took her half the afternoon to prepare; the wine was of the finest quality and, knowing her, she had paid for it even if the Angel's Share would've rather gift her the bottle; and there was also a sweet smell in the air, had she also prepared dessert? No, she could *never* bring herself to reject all of this, no matter how scared she was. Perhaps it is now time to use proper words.

—You know, Jean, despite the great lengths you've gone to prepare all of this I would have believed it's nothing special. However, Dear, you left work earlier... Oh, and I heard you told Marjorie you *couldn't* help her find one of her cats— Lisa pointed out. —You can't deceive me so easily, I know you.

Jean looked away, her face reddened and suddenly she was all too shy.

—I didn't mean to, Lisa... I just don't want you to think you've forgotten some important date or anything— she explained, walking around the table towards her. —I just wanted to do this for you, is that wrong?— she expressed, cupping Lisa's face.

The witch felt a mix of love and sorrow; she wanted nothing more than to melt under her touch, and yet she couldn't allow herself to continue pretending, delaying the inevitable pain for both of them. She grabbed Jean's hand, kissed her knuckles, and let go with a faint smile.

—I appreciate it— she finally let out.

Her voice seemed full of sadness, there was something wrong with Lisa, but Jean failed to understand what. Why had she been so distant lately? Why had she been feeling Lisa avoided her outside their home? It had to be the secrecy, right? Perhaps she feared being discovered, or maybe she had heard someone speaking about them and was now paranoid. Whatever it was, the knight was fixed on settling it that night; they would discuss the matter and solve it together.

—Then I hope you'll enjoy the dinner, it will be ready soon— she replied with a faint smile. She went back into the kitchen and took a deep breath. —How do I even begin?— she wondered, feeling increasingly anxious. —She looks so tired and afraid, she may only shut herself out from the conversation if I ask directly— she reflected. It wouldn't be easy, at all. Jean let out a sigh and checked the pizza; it was ready, so she quickly took it out of the oven and placed it on a tray before taking it to the dining room.—Pizza is here! Hope you're still hungry.

As she placed it on the table, Lisa took a deep breath, already enjoying the smell. Once Jean sat down, they both began eating, all too hungry to speak. A few minutes passed in silence as they ate and the knight kept telling herself she *had* to say something before more time went on.

—It's frankly delicious, Dear— Lisa spoke up before Jean could. —I always enjoy your special pizza so much— she added as she took another slice. —However... I believe I smelled something sweet too, have you also made dessert?— she inquired interestedly.

Jean blushed as she replied —Yes, well... It was supposed to be a surprise but, I did. I wanted to prepare a full meal.

—I see. What will it be? Or do you still want it to be a surprise?— she teased.

—No, it's fine. I... eh, I couldn't decide which one to make; I had a recipe for a Liyue dessert made with almond milk, and there's also the Mint Jelly that always makes for a good dessert. So I made both? In case you didn't like the almond one...— Jean replied with nervousness, which made Lisa chuckle.

—Why are you so uneasy, Jean? Did something happen?

—Of course not, I'm fine... I just feel a little silly. Who makes two different desserts for the same meal?

Giggling, Lisa quickly interrupted —Oh, please, it's fine. That's very *sweet* of you.

Jean's face reddened immediately, she focused on finishing her slice of pizza and tried to ignore the cheese joke. But seeing her so flustered was enough for the witch to keep laughing daintily.

—I had... almost forgotten how corny you can easily be— Jean uttered, unable to look her in the eye. —I feel like we haven't shared a moment in weeks now.

Lisa took a sip of her cup after replying —We have both been too busy, don't you think?

—You know we aren't *actually* much busier, and yet... I feel like we haven't had as much time together as usual— she finally admitted. Jean grabbed her cup, let out a sigh, and looked into it as she asked —Lisa... Is there anything troubling you?

—Jean...

—Or has something I've done bothered you?— she interrupted. —I know I've been getting bolder, careless maybe, and perhaps you're afraid we'll be discovered— Jean babbled. —But, if that's the case— she continued, now looking into Lisa's eyes, —Would it really be *that* bad if people knew?

Lisa's face went pale and she stood up suddenly, her hands planted on the table and her sight down, embarrassed, unwilling to look at the knight.

—Please stop, Jean— she began. —We can't... *I* can't do this to you— the witch stated. —I wanted you to grow tired of me and leave on your own but...—, she let out a pained chuckle, —You're so stubborn, my Love... it's one of your most adorable traits.

Lisa's voice sounded weak and loaded with such anguish it scared Jean, who couldn't help going to her side immediately; she needed to comfort her, to help her calm down so she would explain what she meant. She couldn't really intend to leave her, right?

—Lisa… what… what are you talking about?— she asked, grabbing her hands.

—Jean, I can't do this anymore. I don't want to hurt you— she uttered, but held the knight's hands tightly too. —I can't do this to *you*.

—Hurt me? What are you talking about!? Lisa, please… What happened?

Seeing Jean in such distress felt like a dagger into the witch's heart. She was already hurting her; no matter what she said or did, it would be painful regardless.

—Maybe you should sit down for this, Dear. I have… something important to explain— Lisa finally said. Perhaps it was her voice, perhaps her expression, but something made Jean stay silent and near her chair to sit as close to her as possible. —Remember… Remember how I told you my powers come from an old magical book I once found?— she began, hesitating at first. Jean nodded slowly, her full attention on her, and Lisa continued —Perhaps… *cursed* would be a more appropriate adjective for it. I never told anyone about this but, actually, the book charged a terrible price for the powers it gave me.

—Price… what… What happened to you?

—I rather not bore you with the details, just know that, in exchange for the powers I sought, I resigned half of my life— she finally let out.

—Half your… *What*!? No, wait, wha-what does that mean!?

—Exactly what it sounds like, Jean.

—No, I don't… I don't understand— she denied, stammering.

Lisa cupped her cheek with one hand, keeping their gazes fixed on each other.

Her eyes were already watery as she said —Yes, you understand. You… you understand.

—Lisa, what does it mean? Why are you telling me this now?— Jean sobbed.

Lisa sighed carefully, trying to hold back her tears as she replied —It means… I won't live as much as I should. I… I won't reach old age, I don't really have much time left to live, but I don't really know how soon it will happen so… I should never forget tea time, don't you think?

The witch tried to chuckle dismissively, but she couldn't control it anymore and her tears fell instead. Jean cupped her face and brushed them away with her thumbs, yet she was crying as well.

—Why didn't you say anything before? Why were you trying to push me away?

—I didn't want to- I'm trying to live as if it never happened. And… and I was- no, I *am* so happy with you…— Lisa admitted. She looked at Jean with eyes full of love, genuine care, and a hint of utter sorrow. —But I noticed you were- I realized you want to make us public. Ah… And I know that means you're in for the long run.

—Of course I am!— she immediately exclaimed. —I love you! Lisa, I have no doubts about what I feel!

—That is why I *can't* let you stay with me! I can't do this to you! You want a-a life, a future with me… which I *cannot* give you!— Lisa exclaimed as more tears streamed down. —I apologize, I… I know I'm hurting you regardless, but I simply can't let my selfish feelings crush your dreams and wishes— she added.

—Lisa— Jean sobbed. —*You* are my only wish, my only dream— she replied, trying to strengthen her speech but carefully pronouncing each word despite the lump in her throat. —How could I *possibly* leave you just because we can't grow old together?— she asked, almost indignant, which made the witch tear up further. —I don't care if we only have a couple of years or a couple of months left together. Look at me— she continued, holding Lisa's face between her hands and pressing their foreheads together for a moment. —Look at me and tell me the truth: don't you think my duty puts me in a similar situation to yours? For all we know… heh, I could even die before you.

—No, no. Jean, please… we know you're the strongest knight in Mondstadt, you can be defeated but definitely not slain— Lisa replied instantly.

—You know better than that, my dear witch— Jean insisted, her voice low. —Be honest with me. Haven't you ever feared I wouldn't return?

—I… I suppose I have.

—Then you know how I'm feeling: I might lose you any moment now, yes… but that only makes me cherish our time together even more— she stated. —You once told me you kept

coming to my office for tea every afternoon because you couldn't know when a mission would be my last one.

—I was… teasing you. That would be the only reason you'd accept to have tea time with me every day.

—But you were *right*. We can't know, none of us can know when we're gonna die— Jean insisted. —And I refuse to waste a single second of your precious time. I want to spend whatever time you have left *together*.

—Jean, we have no future, literally! We were never meant to last because you're bound to live longer than me; despite the threats you face, you always have a chance to survive, to live, which I don't have.

—Lisa— she interrupted. —I really mean it when I say I don't care if we have only a few years or a few months; can you believe me when I say even if we only had a few minutes left, I'd still choose you?— she went on, rendering Lisa speechless. —Now I understand I can't waste any more time; any moment I can spend with you, showing how much I love you and being proud of my feelings for you, is precious. Which also means I can't allow it to be a secret anymore, Lisa. We deserve to enjoy our love without fear, either of the future or what will be said.

—Jean…

—My Love, would you… accept being my partner for as long as life lets us?

—Without shame or fear…

—…And making the most of each day.

Lisa nodded as her tears kept falling down and stood up, wanting to hug Jean. The knight held the witch between her arms as she cried against her shoulder.

—I'm so sorry I tried to push you away— Lisa sobbed.

—And I'm sorry you felt it was necessary— Jean replied gently. —We don't have to make plans for the future, I'll be more than glad to live with you one day at the time, and slowly make our way into whatever future we can have together.

—I should have told you sooner…

—You weren't ready. Even now I may have pushed you before you were.

—Ah… I'm glad you did.

Jean gently released her and washed her tears away while smiling tenderly. She never thought she'd see Lisa cry, especially like that. But they had bared their hearts, their crying only proved the sincerity of their feelings.

—Tomorrow will be interesting…— Jean sighed.

Lisa took a deep breath and replied —Perhaps, but leave tomorrow to tomorrow. Now… we better not squander your cooking—. She dried her face and smiled at Jean as she said —I can't wait to try the dessert you've made.

Both of them were even hungrier than before after crying so much and the knight wasted no time taking the remaining pizza back to the kitchen before returning with a plate of Almond Tofu. She observed as the witch tried it and took a deep breath, feeling somewhat lighter, relieved. Whatever time they had ahead of them, she wanted to see more of Lisa's joyful expression, and Jean would make sure they could enjoy more moments like this from now on.

End Notes

This was quite the challenge to write and caught me in the middle of writer's block, so I seriously hope I didn't mess up much; the 20th correction must have been the good one, right?

<3 hope it was to your liking, catgiri

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